you passed on to Pakistan through him, the several meetings you all had in Madras and Trivandrum, and how many millions of dollars you received.'

'See,' I assumed my calm posture again, 'I don't know what Sasi has told you and why. I am not worried about that. The point is that I have done no crime. I just don't understand what you are talking about.'

It must have been night by then. A boy brought me some rice and sambar. I did not touch the food. Now, the two men left the room; another duo took over.

'Tell us, why did you do this?'

This set of interrogators were fresh, but the questions were as tired as me.

'You sold drawings of India's Vikas engine and cryogenic engine to Pakistan,' said one.

'You clearly don't understand rocket science. There are no classified drawings and no drawing has gone out of ISRO. Even if some get the drawings, they can't make such an engine without active collaboration with us for several years. If you don't know, India doesn't have a cryogenic engine; we are still struggling to make one.'

'So you agree that you gave some drawings and documents?'

'No, I said nobody will buy your drawings and documents because nobody can make a rocket out of those papers. Do you know how we acquired the technology of the Viking/Vikas engine you are talking about? We spent 150 man years with French scientists at their facility in Vernon, France under a legal contract. We had hands-on training in everything including fabrication, assembly, testing and result analysis. In spite of all this we took more than sixteen years to make a Vikas engine. It is just not possible to transfer rocket technology by selling drawings and documents. Nobody will buy that.'

'Why not?' Now my interrogator was sounding not just absurd, but impervious to scientific explanation. 'If Pakistan wants to duplicate Viking engine, can't they do it using the drawings you gave?'

'Believe me,' I tried one last time to drive sense into this man who I was not sure was genuinely dull or just acting stupid, 'drawings are not